

Why Do We Like the Music We Like?

By Doc B (<https://thethirdself.com/author/admin/>) on Dec 05, 2020

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Some of my friends have been getting together every Friday night for years to have a “listening party.” Each party has a theme (e.g., time, overthrow of the king, murder, gratitude), and all the participants come ready with ideas of songs, artists, or albums that fit (sometimes loosely) the theme. The host acts as DJ, giving each person a turn to suggest a song, which he plays.

In these days of COVID, the party is held through Zoom. It’s still a lot of fun. I wasn’t one of the old-timers of this party, just attending here and there, but lately I’ve been going each week. Zoom gives me a chance to participate when normally it would be hard to, since I’ve moved away from the town where most of these friends live. It’s a fun way to keep in touch, relax on a Friday evening, share music I like with friends, and hear different music.

In noticing the various genres that each friend likes, I was pondering why we tend to gravitate toward certain types of music. Like most things, there isn’t just one reason. It’s a fascinating topic: How does our individual psychology mesh with culture, society, and experience to shape our musical preferences?

How We Think Shapes Our Music Preferences

A study of more than 4,000 participants led by Cambridge University psychologist David Greenberg and colleagues found a correlation between people's thinking styles and musical preferences. The study divided the subjects into three categories: empathizers (Type E), who focus on people's thoughts and emotions; systemizers (Type S), who focus on rules and systems; and balanced types (Type B), who focus equally on both areas. (What type do you think you are? I think I am Type B.)

In the study, Greenberg and colleagues reviewed the results of the interviews and found that Type E thinkers tended to like low-energy songs with emotional depth, including sad songs, and genres like soft rock and singer-songwriters. Type S thinkers tended to prefer more intense and structured music like heavy metal or avant-garde classical music. Type B personalities tended to display a broader range of preferences than either of the other types.

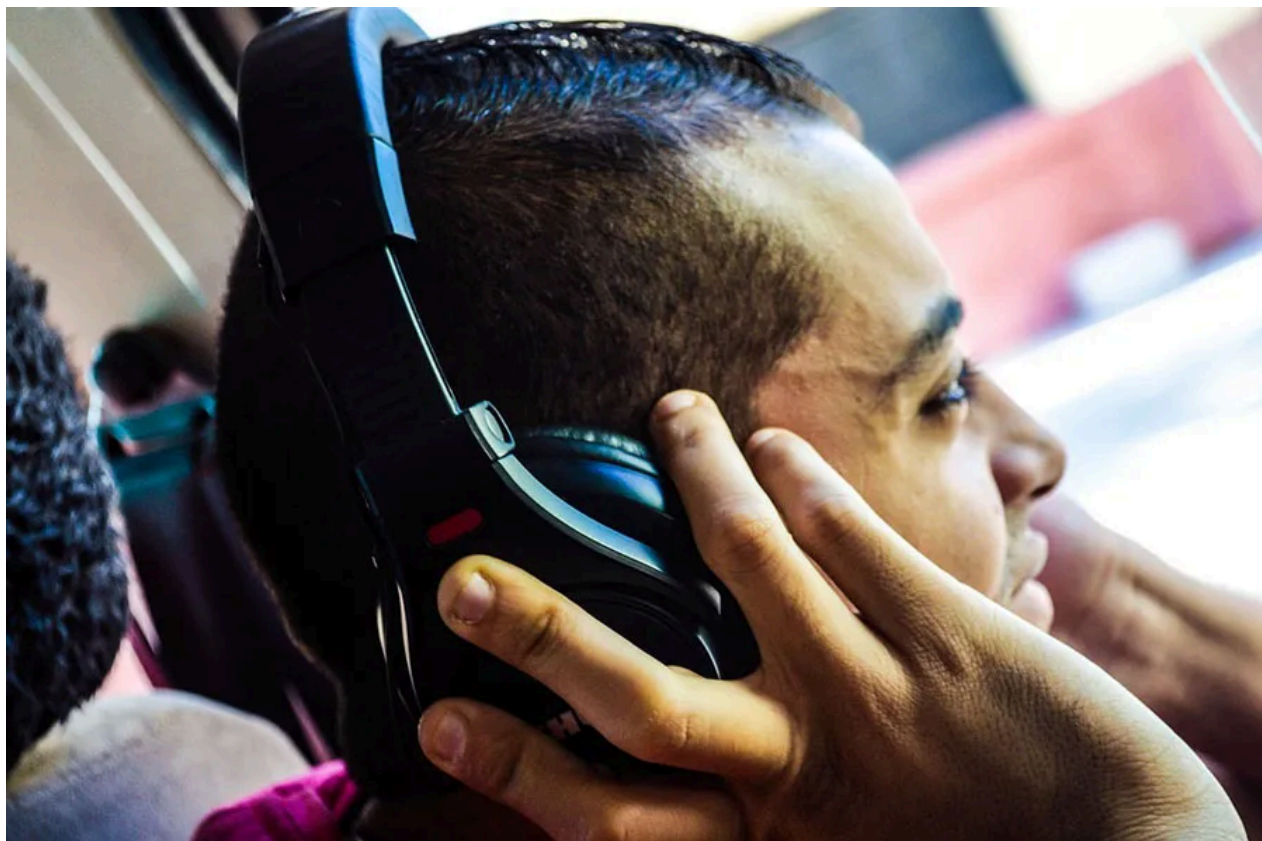


Photo by Mickel Emad.

Prior research suggests that listening to sad music can stimulate the pituitary gland to produce prolactin, which induces calmness and relaxation and is also related to empathy. This is probably more true for Type E people, who may have a larger than average hypothalamic region in the brain, the area governing the pituitary. Other studies show that listening to mellow music can stimulate the production of the hormone oxytocin, which promotes feelings of love, social bonding, well-being, and calm.

In Type S personalities, evidence suggests that the areas of the brain that regulate analytic thought (the cingulate and dorsal medial prefrontal areas) are larger. Type S people were shown to pay more attention to the structure and patterns of music, as well as instrumentation, rather than the emotions.

How Personality Type Factors In

There is also research examining the link between personality types and music genre preferences. One study used the Five Factor Model of analyzing personality types (the qualities are conscientiousness, extroversion, openness, agreeableness, and neuroticism) to see if it fit with music choice. The study found that people who are more open to new experiences liked a wider variety of music, and tended to be drawn to classical music, blues, jazz, and folk music. People in this category tend to be emotional, imaginative, and artistically sensitive, as well as intellectually curious. Extraverts tended to like popular music. An earlier, similar, study also found that extroverts often are drawn to higher-energy and rhythmic music.



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One Canadian study found that certain personality traits relate to musical taste in adolescents: Young people with lower self-esteem and a higher sense of alienation were more drawn to “heavy” music, and those who tended to focus on rule-following and have

trouble being independent preferred “light” music. Adolescents who felt relatively secure and confident tended to have more eclectic musical preferences.

Additional Factors in Musical Preference

Gender plays a role in why we like certain music. According to some research, female gender is associated with a more emotional response to music and a tendency to prefer pop. Male gender is correlated with liking exaggerated bass in music.

Age is an additional factor. Not surprisingly, young people are often more open to new music and more likely to listen to what’s contemporary, compared with older people, who often are drawn to music they liked when they were younger. Musical tastes also change over the lifespan.

History, Culture, and Experience Also Affect Music Taste

We don’t exist in a vacuum. Our thinking and personality styles are in part shaped by genetics but also by environment. This includes our family, peers, and larger culture and community. For instance, psychology research shows that people are drawn to the familiar. Thus, some of our musical taste is shaped by what we hear as children and young adults.



A 2016 study published in *Nature* found that hundreds of years’ of learned behavior factor into why we prefer certain styles of music. This study looked specifically at music with consonant intervals (e.g., using octaves) versus that which is dissonant (e.g., using tritones). Consonant intervals generally sound brighter and feel more “resolved.” Dissonant intervals, on the other hand, tend to sound harsher and unfinished. People from Western cultures strongly prefer consonant music. The study found that people from non-Western cultures with no exposure to Western music equally enjoyed consonant and

dissonant music. This research disproved the previously believed theory that preference for consonant music is biologically determined and universal. Thus, over time, our culture shapes what sounds pleasing and familiar to us.

We are also drawn to certain genres because of what it says to and about us; for example, we may listen to music from our racial or ethnic culture or the geographical region where we grew up. According to some studies, music preferences are also influenced by how an individual wants to be perceived—the music a person chooses is a form of self-expression and a reflection of conscious and unconscious identity traits. This was found to be more true for males than for people of other genders. Thus, we are drawn to music that represents something we relate to, such as intelligence (e.g., classical music, jazz), rebellion (e.g., heavy metal, countercultural folk music, punk), or a certain subculture (e.g., rockabilly, bluegrass, goth).



Images from James Mollison's book *The Disciples*, a visual study of musical subcultures. Top: Missy Elliott fans. Middle: The Cure fans. Bottom: Sex Pistols fans. Artist website: <https://www.jamesmollison.com/>.

Music choice is also personal—we associate certain songs or bands with a memory or a person. For instance, maybe our first love was into a particular band. We may begin listening to that band as a way to get closer to our partner, but eventually, we grow to love the band—even after the relationship is over. Haven't you ever heard a song start playing that reminds you of high school dances or your twenties or a favorite vacation and instantly start to feel good?

It's fascinating to think about all of these factors. In the end, though, why we listen to what we listen to may not matter a whole lot. It's the experience and richness of music that we care about, regardless of how we got there.

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